Typographic Notes

1.
The choice of type size for reading is dependant on the particular typeface (some faces look smaller or larger than others at the same point size). The most common type sizes for reading at up to arm's-length would be 9-12 pt, but depending on the length of text, some designers will employ sizes as small as 7 pt. Small type sizes have been considered chic by some graphic designers. On a functional level one should consider the end user/audience. The RNIB (Royal National Institute for the Blind) have guidelines for minimum type sizes for people with visual impairments. Poster design requires a different type of decision-making; it is not just an enlarged flyer. Posters should be judged at actual size and from the distance they are likely to be seen from. A too-small type size is the most common issue with posters. The two issues to consider are legibility and readability. Most typography is legible, but readability is the measure by which one is inclined to read the particular information.

2.
Leading, line spacing, and line feed are all terms for the space between lines. Space is inserted between lines in order to aid readability. A guide might be that the longer the line the more leading is required, and conversely the shorter the line the less leading is needed. The term "leading" derives from letterpress where lines are spaced using strips of lead.

3.
The measure is the width over which type is set. For normal reading conditions, between seven to ten words per line is considered optimum, although this can vary either way. One should be aware that long lines, i.e., twenty or more words, are tiring to read. A short measure requires the reader to change line more frequently, which interrupts the reading flow. Lines of type within small amounts of text are split both for their appearance (to create an even ragged right edge) and for their sense. You need to read the copy in order to make decisions about its appearance.

4.
Typographic contrast is achieved through various means such as a change in weight, size, position, colour, etc. The aim is to create a change in emphasis and therefore the change needs to be perceptible. Some designers feel that the difference between Gill Sans Regular and Gill Sans Bold is not particularly significant. If one is using size to gain emphasis it is unlikely that 1 pt difference will be perceived. You might consider a more mathematically satisfying relationship, e.g., 9 pt and 18 pt. Think logically about the contrast to begin with; intuitive decisions are a lot harder initially and require some experience.

5.
Grid structures are useful for bringing all elements of the design into a harmonious relationship. Simple structures subdivide the available space into proportional divisions, e.g., thirds or quarters (both horizontally and vertically). Margins are used in order to contain the elements within the edges of the format. A space is often inserted between the divisions so that elements such as the type are contained within a prescribed width and do not clash with the elements in the next column. These divisions are often known as "units" (e.g., an A4 sheet divided into three both horizontally and vertically has a nine-unit field). Not all designs employ a grid; simple typographic arrangements might make stronger relationships between individual words to enhance meaning and communication.

TYPESETTING REVIEW

You are expected to produce one personal review and two peer reviews of the result of the previous typography assignment. State what you liked about the reviewee's work and what could be done to improve it. A list of strengths and weaknesses will do; make general comments about the concept and layout before you write down any specific issues. Remember, all comments are meant to be constructive!

In addition to your general comments, the following guidelines can be used to inform feedback:

i. For optimum legibility choose classical, time-tested typefaces with a proven track record.

ii. Be mindful not to use too many different typefaces at any one time.

iii. Avoid combining typefaces that are too similar in appearance.

iv. Text set entirely in capital letters severely hinders reading. Use uppercase and lowercase letters for optimum readability.

v. For text type, use sizes that have proven most readable in legibility studies.

vi. Avoid using too many different type sizes and weights at the same time.

vii. Use text types of book weight (regular, roman). Avoid typefaces that appear too heavy or too light.

viii. Use text types of medium width. Avoid typefaces that appear extremely wide or narrow.

ix. For text type, use consistent letterspacing and word spacing to produce an even texture.

x. Use appropriate line lengths. Lines that are too short or too long disrupt the reading process.

xi. For text type, use line spacing that easily carries the eye from one line to the next.

xii. For optimum readability, use a flush left, ragged right type alignment.

xiii. Strive for consistent rhythmic rags.

xiv. Clearly indicate paragraphs, but be careful not to upset the integrity and visual consistency of the text.

xv. Avoid widows and orphans. A widow is a word or very short line at the beginning or end of a paragraph. An orphan is a single syllable at the end of a paragraph.

xvi. Emphasize elements within text with discretion and without disturbing the flow of reading.

xvii. Always maintain the integrity of the typeface. Avoid arbitrarily stretching letters.

xviii. Always align letters and words on the baseline.

xix. When working with colour and type, ensure that there is sufficient contrast.

xx. Break every rule! (Well, at least identify the ones you've broken on purpose.)

TYPOGRAPHIC DICTIONARY

Find a definition for each of the terms listed below. Choose at least fifteen of them to create your personal typographic dictionary.

Terms:

- accent
- ascender
- baseline
- body copy
- bold
- bowl
- cap-height
- contrast
- counter
- descender
- font family
- golden section
- geometric
- greyscale
- grotesque
- grid
- headline
- height
- humanist
- hyphenation
- initial cap
- justified
- kerning
- letterspacing
- leading
- line length
- legibility
- lowercase
- meanline
- negative space
- numeral
- orphan
- odd
- outline
- open-source
- point size
- pica
- punctuation
- rag
- readable
- reduction
- rhythm
- reverse type
- script
- serif
- sans serif
- small caps
- symbol
- system
- tracking
- uppercase
- underline
- unjustified
- visual hierarchy
- vernacular
- vertical
- white space
- word
- x-height

The project:

Create a spread for each typographic term. On the left-hand page write a short personal description about the importance of the term for you as a designer and how it relates to shaping space and creating visual hierarchy. On the right-hand page you will create a visual interpretation of the term.

Define a typographic grid to help you structure the different levels of content of your dictionary.

Final format:

The size of the book is to be determined by you, with the limitation that your spread should be no larger than 19 × 40.5 cm. Your dictionary will be printed black and white and spiral bound.

TYPEFACES (ABOUT)

Typography is a tradition. It's easy to forget the extent to which the ways that we read, design, and print are shaped by culture- and technology-specific history. In this assignment, each of you will research the many facets of the historical reality of a single typeface.

- Akzidenz-Grotesk
- Antique Olive
- Avenir
- Balance
- Bell Centennial
- Beowolf
- Bodoni
- Caslon
- Century
- Comic Sans
- Courier
- DIN
- Fette Fraktur
- Fleischmann
- Franklin Gothic
- Futura
- Garamond
- Gill Sans
- Helvetica
- Hobo
- Hollandsche Mediæval
- Janson
- Jenson
- Joanna
- Mercator
- Meta-the-difference-between-the-two-Font
- Minion
- Mistral
- Monotype Grotesque
- New Alphabet
- Rotis
- Swift
- Times New Roman
- Trajan
- Trinité
- Univers
- Verdana
- Windsor

You will be assigned one typeface that is relevant to the history of Latin-alphabet Western typography from the list on the left. Most of them are so-called text faces; some would be called display faces; some are more conceptual/experimental projects.

Your edited research will take the shape of a set of interlinked websites. A website will be the ideal medium in which to explore the qualities of contemporary font technology (digital PostScript fonts) and how that relates to type history.

A couple of questions to get the juices flowing: When was this typeface designed? By whom? For which type foundry? For which typesetting/printing technology? How do those technologies work exactly? How did this influence the design? Under which commercial considerations or constraints has it been made? What makes this design unique? Was it based on another typeface? What has been its influence since? What has it been used for? Does it embody or is it associated with certain values, ideologies, methods, artistic movements…? Has it been appropriated or used for markedly different values? Is it presented as being made with a singular concept in mind? If the typeface has been adapted to different typesetting technologies, what are the differences between the different versions? What qualities have been lost and gained? How was it marketed in the past; how is it marketed now? Who owns the rights?

DESIGN MANUAL

Design is governed by a series of rules and principles, from the use of tools ("Before phoning, make clear notes of what facts you are going to transmit, especially figures", Ken Garland), visual codes ("1:2, 2:3, 3:5", Fibonacci) and production processes ("Essential for every binding … is a spine title", Jost Hochuli), to client relations ("Clients don't have their company logo in a usable print ready format so don't bother asking", www.graphicdesignforum.com), moral applications ("The service rendered to the world by printers is best talked about by those who are served", Eric Gill), or ethical principles ("Would you design a prison? If not, why not?", Norman Potter). Every element represents a choice defining and positioning a designer's practice, with the application of a methodology being a statement in itself ("Have read at least once 'How to Work Better' by Fischli & Weiss", Norm).

How do today's models exist in relation to past models? How do we learn from other transversal practices? When do these models become normative? What are their alternatives?

Assignment:

Investigate different design methodologies either by republishing an existing manual; by creating a manual articulating a personal view of professional practices; or by applying the rules of another manual or mentor.

Points for reflection:

Practical design elements, applicable guidelines, methodologies, client relations, ethical codes, life-rules.

FREE PROJECT

Make a project with the theme and technique of your choosing, except for the restrictions on the back:

General:

01. Forbidden to make less than fifty illustrations.
02. Forbidden to make to make a sound project.
03. Forbidden to make a moving image project.
04. Forbidden to make performances.
05. Forbidden to make a project as an exhibition.
06. Forbidden to make a sculpture project.

Illustration:

07. Forbidden to use a photographic camera.
08. Forbidden to use a lightbox or to do tracing.
09. Forbidden to make designs with more than five parallel lines less than 1 cm apart.
10. Forbidden to make structures out of triangles, or derived from triangles.
11. Forbidden to represent human beings.
12. Forbidden to use the colours red and black together.
13. Forbidden to use the colours blue and orange together.
14. Forbidden to use any Adobe software.
15. Forbidden to refer to politics, religion, or death.

Printing of the final object:

16. Forbidden to use a laser printer.
17. Forbidden to use a digital printer.
18. Forbidden to use an inkjet printer.
19. Forbidden to use a photocopier.
20. Forbidden to use linocut.

Formats:

21. Forbidden to use any DIN A formats.
22. Forbidden to use formats based on the golden section.
23. Forbidden to use the proportions of Jan Tschichold.
24. Forbidden to use square formats.
25. Forbidden to use formats with diagonals over 3 m.
26. Forbidden to use formats with diagonals under 12 cm.

Typography:

27. Forbidden to not have the title of the project visible.
28. Forbidden to not have an index.
29. Forbidden to use page numbers.
30. Forbidden to use more than one or less than eight typefaces.
31. Forbidden to use more than one cut per font.
32. Forbidden to use more than three sizes per font.
33. Forbidden to use system fonts.
34. Forbidden to use any font available on the school computers.
35. Forbidden to use typographic strokes.
36. Forbidden to use underscores.

Final object:

37. Forbidden to use T-shirts.
38. Forbidden to hand in originals.
39. Forbidden to use stitched binding.
40. Forbidden to use ring binding.
41. Forbidden to make less than three copies of the final object.
42. Forbidden to use 80 gsm and 90 gsm Xerox paper.
43. Forbidden to use papers available from the school shop.

Behaviour:

44. Forbidden to not show anything during the course.
45. Forbidden to not be present at all classes from 8.30 am to 12 pm (except with medical certificate).
46. Forbidden to work on another project during the course.
47. Forbidden to change subject after three lessons.
48. Forbidden to discuss the project with the teacher outside of class hours.
49. Forbidden to question the word of the teachers.
50. Forbidden to protest against all present or future prohibitions.

USELESS

As graphic designers we have many tools at our disposal to help us with our work. As these tools become more and more advanced it may seem that they can do half the work for us. But actually they are still just tools, and how we use them defines the result - they can't generate ideas for us. I want you to challenge the predetermined functions of these tools and find new tools to work with.

Do one of the following each week:

- Make a picture in a text-editing program.
- Write a text with a digital camera.
- Scan a three-dimensional object.
- Make music with Illustrator.
- Measure an object in Photoshop.
- Copy a work of a classmate.
- Trace a story.
- Draw the rear side of an interface.
- Spreadsheet a photograph.
- Draw a landscape with guides.
- Scan paper.
- Photograph an alphabet.
- Scan a tool.
- Design an e-mail.
- Print a colour with a black-and-white printer.
- Or add something to the list and do that.

Present the result in A4 format. There will be no excuses for not having something new to present at each class!

These actions may seem absurd or pointless, but I want you to take them seriously. Interpret these actions freely, but make an effort to realize them. Or find alternative ways to manage one of the actions. Try to challenge yourself, push the limits of each action, try to approach each action without knowing the end result.